CONCLUSION

This book has argued that Myanmar stands on the edge of genocide and that the persecution of the Rohingyas has been quite deliberately constructed by the state since the early 1960s. The return to relative democracy has seen the Rohingyas' situation deteriorate rather than improve, and again this reflects the deliberate policy of the Myanmar elite.[1] In order to understand why this has happened it is useful to summarise some of the key arguments advanced in the previous chapters.

First, the NLD and the USDP/military share, at an elite level, the same background. Their differences can be traced back to the debates before and after independence about whether, and to what extent, the new country should be inclusive of all who lived there or should only be for ethnic Burmans, or, slightly more generously, for those who accepted Buddhism. Senior leaders of the NLD share the background of their notional opponents. Aung San Suu Kyi's father was one of the leaders of the independence movement and her mother was a minister in the post-independence civilian governments. The NLD's vice-chairman was in charge of the army until he was sacked after leading a failed coup. Others have similar personal backgrounds.

Second, the NLD claims to sit in the Burmese (and indeed Indian) political tradition of being both a mass movement and an elite organisation. In the period before independence this saw nationalists in both Burma and India try to fuse together a combination of an educated elite, armed revolt and mass street protests. After 1988 the elite in the NLD effectively joined up with the students and the Buddhist monks who were leading protests. However, they made little direct connection with the peasantry or the small Burmese working class and gained almost no support among Burma's many ethnic minorities.

The USDP is clearly an artificial political force designed to give the generals an electoral vehicle. It has real power due to its control over the